

THE CROSSROADS

ANAND UTSAV EDITION

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**COLLEGE SUCCESS:
THE CIRS SPELL**
Bhakti Thummar - Alumna



THE CIRS EFFECT
The Editorial

TAKING THE BIG SHOT
Preetham Rampeesa

SEPTEMBER – OCTOBER 2024 / ISSUE 19

September - October 2024 | Issue 19



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College Success: The CIRS Spell

Bhakti Thummar - CIRS Alumna



The CIRS Effect

K. NISHANTH

CROSSROADS TEAM



CIRS - a 'School with a Difference.' I had the privilege of joining this esteemed institution back in 2019. Only, I didn't realize just how privileged I was until after several years of escape plans, resentment, hatred and sorrow. Now that I take a stroll down memory lane, I feel rather disgusted at my former self and only wish that I had made better use of my precious time here.

Well to start off, let me tell you something about my former self. I was wider than I was tall, and immature and ignorant about the way the world worked. But that didn't stop me from going around complaining about everything under the sun. I didn't like the morning jogging, I didn't like the evening aartis and I absolutely detested sports. However, these 'not likes' aren't the only reasons why I consider my past self lifeless. It's because I had no goal whatsoever in life. My thoughts revolved only around how long I could sleep or how much I could eat. Essentially, I considered myself more superior the more I resembled an animal! That is exactly what the 'CIRS Effect' cured. It made me human, and is even today molding me into the upright and righteous youth that I envisioned myself to be.

This process of change was definitely not accomplished in one fell swoop. It was not a sudden change in my mindset, but a gradual series of realizations. The first of which was sports. From a guy who bunked jogging on a regular basis to one who now never misses early jogging, I've changed quite a bit. Basketball has played quite a pivotal part in my journey of transformation. Other than giving me a goal to focus on, basketball honed my physical prowess and mental capabilities.

I came to see the value of hard work, dedication and self discipline. Developing these qualities on the court also helped me strengthen and reflect these virtues in every other sphere of life. Embracing pain was perhaps the most vital element for my growth and the years in CIRS really hammered it into my subconscious. I realized that when you have an aspiration, it propels you forward so fast that you exceed milestone after milestone. This made me understand that a 'maximum level' is only a mental shackle which I willingly wear that hinders my development. Limits are just perceptions which require hard work to transcend, but that can be initiated with just a little mindset switch. We were born into this world to learn and excel, and CIRS has taught me that the pursuit of these two is a lifelong process.

When I first arrived, I took some time to get used to the hectic schedule here, which at first glance seemed to be completely packed. But upon closer inspection, I found several gaps; productive utilization of which is the key to rising above the flock. Correctly utilizing those gaps, those little stepping stones of opportunity, is what enabled me to write this article, play extra sports, read actual books and reach a level of my own. This is also a result of the 'CIRS Effect' - effective time management. Everyone has the same 24 hours, be it the CEO of a Fortune 500 company or a clerk in said company. How people utilize their time is what defines their position in the world. When I began to implement this powerful affirmation, I soon lost count of how many times I had to be in multiple places at once, and also juggle an equal number of responsibilities. Of course, I still managed to squeeze in time to have an absurd amount of fun with my friends.

But more than all these things that have forged me into the person I am today, I have learnt to value the memories that I made here. From waiting for paneer and sambar days to just laughing with my friends. From the adrenaline rush of running across the court to taking an introspective night walk to the Hanuman temple. These memories stand testament to the bond I share with my friends and teachers. They really push me to face every new day and work like it's my last. Here I have made friendships and learnt skills that I know will last a lifetime. CIRS spent all these years giving me opportunities to meet myself - a great person whom I would have never known had I not come here. Uncovering my true identity, knowing why I'm here, and always giving my best are all things that I have learnt during my time here. Words are not enough to express my near infinite gratitude to this magical land which somehow makes it rain exactly at sports time.

If I could meet myself five years ago, I wouldn't have much advice to give the other person. For after experiencing it myself, I believe that the 'CIRS Effect' really worked for me, just as it did for countless others before me, and will for the many more to come. I now know that no matter the student, no matter the situation, CIRS, the 'School with a Difference' can and will create thinkers, believers and changemakers from scratch time and time again.



BEYOND THE SYMPHONIES

Music's role in shaping Global Culture

KESHAV BANGUR | IB I YR, CIRS

The influence that music holds over an individual and society is boundless; it is a universal language which manages to enhance individuals in multiple dimensions. It holds the ability to evoke emotions, mold narratives and provide solace in times of hardship. In fact, numerous studies have also verified the positive impact of music in shaping mindsets, improving mental health and treating a variety of other conditions. One of the most significant ways music has shaped society is through its ability to morph cultural identity. From ancient eras to modern day protests, music has helped in molding nationalist feelings and sparking a revival of cultural pride. Throughout the years, music has also been a great source of inspiration for collective action on several social issues.

One such incident occurred during the Civil Rights Movement in the United States, a dark time in American history when the African-Americans conducted extensive protests, marches and boycotts to resist the racial discrimination imposed upon them. During this tense period, songs such as 'We Shall Overcome' and 'A Change Is Gonna Come' served as anthems of unity and resistance, and acted as beacons of hope while rallying public support.

In the USA, the African-American community was always considered a 'minority', and this stereotype gravely impacted the lives of many people. During this time, a hero, who managed to leave a huge impact on society, arose from the shadows. This hero was Tupac Shakur, a living testament to the phrase "Music speaks when words fail." His work was nothing short of vocal advocacy for social justice and equality. His words motivated a generation of young people to fight for the right cause, and he used his platform to raise much needed awareness on racial profiling, social equality and the criminal justice system. Even today, his legacy continues to inspire artists and activists all over the world.

The East India Company that had captured India used the strategy of infectious colonization on the Indian minds. Their influence made

the natives look down on the culture they once identified with. In the process, the British cracked the collective belongingness of Indians by suppressing Indian musical culture and implementing Western values. During this grim point in time, Alla Rakha Khan, a legendary tabla maestro, played an exceptional role in shaping India's identity through music. His performances were recognized throughout the country, reaching a wide range of people, and were the unseen forces that fostered cultural heritage amongst all Indians.

Cultural differences were an integral part of the rising concerns that have undeniably impacted our society. During those times, the world was in dire need of a hero who could help in breaking these cultural barriers. In India, Ravi Shankarji, one such cultural ambassador, paved the way for cultural fusion. His innovative approach, an idea to blend Indian music with Western musicians, like George Harrison, inspired many and laid the foundation to bridging cultural divides whilst introducing Indian culture to a wider, much more global audience.

Similarly, Michael Jackson, often referred to as the 'King of Pop', was not only a multi-talented



superstar; he was one of the most influential and impactful souls of the century. His genre-defying music revolutionized the pop industry. His unique fashion and infamous signature moves helped him break language barriers, allowing him to connect to his audience like never seen before. As a colored artist, Jackson was always prey to racial prejudices; but he never let that become a barrier to achieving his dreams. His fame let him succeed in promoting racial equality and



also in addressing social issues. The influence of music transcends social issues; it also aids in constructing history itself. The success of 'The Beatles' in the United States, commonly referred to as the 'British Invasion', popularized British culture all over the world. Their innovative music style connected fans of different genres around the world. Their popularity spread like wildfire and served as a peaceful connection between two superpowers of the world - the United States and the Soviet Union - during the Cold War, ultimately helping in softening tensions. Their immense popularity made British culture - film, literature and its renowned fashion styles - stand out. Furthermore, The Beatles' melodies manage to inspire and resonate with audiences till this day.

In a nutshell, music is more than just entertainment. It is a universal language that can inspire, unite and uplift. The Beatles' music popularized British culture, Alla Rakha Khan's performances cultivated nationalism amongst Indians, Tupac's lyrics gave voice to marginalized communities, and Ravi Shankar's innovative



approach to cultural fusion introduced Indian music to a wider audience. These examples, and many more, stand testament to the enduring power of human creativity and expression in the form of music. Today, as we continue to navigate the complexities of the modern world, music will undoubtedly remain a powerful tool to foster understanding and instill collective identity, and will continue to enrich our lives in innumerable ways.

THE FOOTSTEPS IN WHICH WE FOLLOW...

THE EDITORIAL TEAM '24



We have been left with big shoes to fill and bigger expectations to live up to. We, their successors, are honored to tread the path they have paved, and hope to inspire others as they have inspired us. For all your support and guidance...

Thank you!

THE LOOP

PRISHA KANTESARIA | GRADE 10, CIRS

Every morning, as we drag ourselves out of bed and get ready for a bright new day; the very first thought that comes to our mind is, "Agh! I don't want to get up to experience the same old thing all over again." The cozy bed calls out to you, radiating warmth, comfort and blissful sleep. So, when it's time to bid farewell to your mattress, things tend to get a little messy.

But this article isn't about the laziness of a person, it's the tale of "The Loop". This loop that I'm talking about here is a really simple thing. Many of us have at some point in time, been trapped in this vicious loop. We watch as the weeks go by, as we fall ever deeper into the cycle of lethargy and inertia. Every day seems very similar, sometimes so alike that it feels like you're living the same day over and over again.

The mere thought of repeating the same actions over and over again intimidates you. It pushes you deeper into your comfort zone, bringing on the feeling of wanting to remain in your cozy bed. No matter how motivated one is, repeating the same thing again and again leads to boredom, negative thoughts and the idea of giving up.

This loop may not seem too important right now, but it plays a major role in stunting the intellectual growth of an individual. The loop binds you to itself; and soon enough you get so accustomed to it that even minor obstacles in your path loom as large as Mount Everest. You get so engrossed in this loop that you stop trying new things, and start straying towards the easier path. Worst of all, you stop dreaming and aspiring to achieve greater goals. Your vision gets bound to the loop, bringing your growth as an intellectual to a dead end. At this stage, you are really only a helpless cog caught in this vicious cycle.

One way to escape this loop is to focus on what you're doing in the present. As our dear Gurudev rightly said, "Put your mind where your hands are!" If you concentrate on what you're doing at that particular moment, the same boring job starts to interest you. So much so that you start enjoying it. You become eager to know and learn more. As a result, you start to love this new loop of positivity, and it will actually help you become better at what you do.

I myself have been through this loop many times. A lot of my days have gone by in such a dull manner. Since we all exist in the real world and not in an Indian TV serial, sometimes your days are bound to be uneventful and monotonous. But we should know that this loop of the same day repeating itself over and over again has an end. We must not let it overpower us, and instead learn to use it for our benefit. Ultimately, just remember that every sunrise marks a new day, and instead of starting it with a frown, we should start it with a smile.



TAKING THE BIG SHOT

PREETHAM RAMPEESA | GRADE 10, CIRS

LIVE



Have you ever woken up one day and said to yourself, "Today feels like a day I'm going to do absolutely nothing." I'm sure we've all been down that road at least once. If you're no stranger to this feeling, then gear up for an expedition that will change the way you perceive life.

I still remember those days when I was around 6 years old, back when I used to say, "Papa, I want to be an astronaut". Or, as my passion was, and still is, "I want to be a sportsperson". At that time, not even the sky was the limit. Each path held its own candescent welcome sign in front of it. But as I grew up, I started fearing whether I'd make it or not. Distractions faced me at every turn I took. My mind was bombarded with thoughts of failure, and soon I began wallowing in self doubt.

It was then that I heard these lines: "Man's greatest fear is not dreaming big and failing; it's having a mediocre dream and succeeding". I realized that

everyone had the same amount of time - 24 hours in a day and 365 days in a year. So, clearly, time wasn't the real problem. The deciding factor that set apart those who made it from those who got swept away by the tides of distraction and fear was merely the way in which they utilized those precious minutes.

It can be unnerving sometimes, not knowing which way you're headed, but don't let that stop you from giving your best. Every second that slips away from you, you lose a small part of the person you could've been. Take two words that are rather familiar to us - 'studying' and 'Sunday'. Terms that should never be used in the same sentence. But what if you read just one page of a concept you didn't understand in class every day of the week, including Sunday? Now imagine you carried on the same work ethic for the next week, and the one after that. Wouldn't exams pass like a breeze, giving you more time to pursue your passion?

Now imagine a person who runs a single lap around a 400 meter track a day. Compare him to a person who runs 2 laps of the same track. Now, there is a difference of just one lap, right? But by the end of a month, the first person would've run only 12 kilometers whereas the second would have run 24 kilometers. By the end of the year, the first runs a mere 146 km; nothing compared to the whopping 292 km of the second. Now these two people aren't characters from some fairytale. They are both you. That feeling that someone is pulling you down, not letting you reach for the stars? That inhibitor of excellence is you and you alone. At the same time, the person who motivates you to get up no matter how many times you fall down is also you.

It's compelling when you win, and it should be even more compelling when you lose. That's because every failure opens up a thousand different angles from which you can look at life. You must stop repenting for the past. Start from a grassroots level if

LIFE KING SIZE



“

*Only the sailor
knows where
and how he
can steer his ship;
true direction
lies within
the seeker.*

”

you must, but do not give up, come hell or high water. Not until you're done, not until you've finished.

You must also have a goal that you are adamant on achieving, and you must be really willing to dedicate your entire life to it. It is then that all these petty distractions will be but specks of dust in the heaven of your making. Only the sailor knows where and how he can steer his ship; true direction lies within the seeker. Remember how I told you about all those paths with radiant signs echoing your name? Well, there's no telling whether you're going to make it or not. Life's just made that way, and there's nothing you can do about it. But at least you won't be left with a dreadful thought about that one path you did not take.

On a concluding note, just know that it's never too late. If one path doesn't work, go for another. Or even better, pave your own! When you look back at yourself 40 years down the line, there should

be a big smile etched onto your face, for you know that you're standing there because of all the hard work you have put in. At the end of the day, your laurels will speak for you. So the next time you feel like doing absolutely nothing, just remember that you get only one shot at this game called life. Why waste it, then, when you have a chance to ace it?



STHITA PRAJÑĀ

Chyft
CIRS

स्थितप्रज्ञस्य का भाषा समाधिस्थस्य केशव |
स्थितधीः किं प्रभाषेत किमासीत ब्रजेत किम् ॥ 54 ॥

O KRISHNA, WHO IS A STHITA PRAJÑĀ? HOW DOES HE TALK?
HOW DOES HE SIT? HOW DOES HE WALK?
- BHAGAVAD GITA 2.54

In this busy and fast moving world of today, no matter what happens, we somehow manage to lose our mental stability. With a mind that is blown about like a feather by the winds of desires, most of our actions prove to be ineffective and useless. So, why do we become intellectually fickle? Is it because of some problem that's affecting us, or is it just overthinking?



Well, most of us are undoubtedly emotionally oriented people, with various biases clouding our perspectives and judgments. Furthermore, we also look at problems through a lens of bias and insecurity. Following such a huge error in judgment, we fall into the trap of emotions, and consequently lose our capacity to think clearly. Now arises the million dollar question: how do we solve this problem? As a great man once said, "Problems are a part of life, and solving them is the art of life!" Our ancient rishis have given us a tried and tested method to avoid entering this labyrinth of extreme internal and intellectual confusion. What is it, you ask? The answer is simple - become a sthita prajñā!

Firstly, let us understand what the term 'sthita prajñā' really means. 'Sthita' means 'stability', and 'prajñā' means 'intellect'.

Thus, the word 'sthita prajñā' literally means 'a stable intellect', a state of equanimity and balance. One who does not get affected by any situation; one who is never too happy or too sad. Such a stable, calm and peaceful man is a sthita prajñā. His intellect judges and acts without any bias or ego. Additionally, a the character of a sthita prajñā is free from the ill effects of negative emotions such as anger, fear and jealousy. Such a potent individual will act as a catalyst for the nation to develop and progress. Now, another question arises: "Is such a person going to be a lifeless creature, with no feelings for anyone or anything?"

The truth is that a man who has mastered the storms of his heart will never become a lifeless creature with no emotions. On the contrary, he will be more lively than most of us. Unaffected by any problem or situation and knowing that true happiness lies within, he stands tall with confidence and a bright smile. His smile is not a temporary adornment, but an eternal gem which shines through him. Independent of the transitory joys derived from the materialistic world of objects, he remains ever blissful through all situations in life.

This state of equanimity that one must achieve is not a goal to be put off until one's retirement or old age. Although this knowledge of the true nature of the Self is beneficial to Man at any and every point in his life, it is most practical in his dynamic youth. For it is at this time that his uncontrolled emotions run riot and sway him

from the path of dharma - that which is right. However, youth is also that beautiful stage of life when individuals can give their best to the building of the nation and the progress of the world. Hence, it is now the need of the hour for each and every one of us to tirelessly work to cultivate this state of harmonious balance within ourselves. After all, to quote our Pujya Gurudev, "Through Individual Transformation alone, World Transformation can be aspired!" Thus, let us all strive to transcend the problems of our daily life. Let us all revel in the state of Supreme Bliss, every moment of every day. Let us all become true sthita prajñās.

PARALYMPICS

DHRUVIK AGARWAL | II MGMT, CIRS

The world recently stood spectator to the globe's largest sporting event - The Olympics. After a four-year-long wait, various countries took the stage to showcase their sporting prowess. Every person in the world, even those who may not be into sports, have passable knowledge about this celebration of sporting glory. But if everyone is already aware about this momentous event, then why talk about it? Well, this article is not about the Olympics, but about something that happens right after the Olympics. This is something which even the most die-hard sports enthusiasts tend to neglect - the Paralympics!

The international Paralympic Games are organized to integrate specially-abled people worldwide, and provide them with a platform to represent their nation. Over the past few decades, there have been significant developments in this sporting event, helping it acquire quite a reputation. However, to fully understand the Games' present state, one must delve deeper into how they began.

In 1944, a Dr. Ludwig Guttmann opened a spinal injuries center at Stoke Mandeville Hospital in Great Britain. This center was established to rehabilitate World War II veterans suffering from spinal cord injuries. Recognizing that physical activity could speed up recovery and improve mental well-being, Guttmann began incorporating sports into the rehabilitation process.

On July 29, 1948, coinciding with the Opening Ceremony of the London Olympics, Dr. Guttmann organized the first competition for wheelchair athletes known as the Stoke Mandeville Games.

The success of this first competition inspired Guttmann to continue organizing similar events. Gradually evolving from its humble beginnings as a mere recreational activity into a renowned competition, Dr. Guttmann's brainchild soon led to the creation of the Paralympic Games.

Thus, the Paralympic Games represent a significant milestone in the world of sports, showcasing the phenomenal abilities of differently abled athletes. Established to promote inclusivity and challenge societal perceptions about disability, the Paralympics have now become a major international sporting event that rivals even the Olympic Games.

The 1988 Summer Paralympics were the first after 24 years to take place in the same city as the Olympic Games. Held in Seoul, South Korea, this was also the first time the term 'Paralympic' was officially used. Finally, from the 2008 Beijing Olympics,



it was decided that the Paralympics and the Olympics would take place in the same host city.

The 2008 Beijing Paralympics proved to be the most successful Paralympic Games in history in terms of number of participants, number of records broken and number of spectators tuning into the games. The sheer number of athletes and nations participating in the Paralympic Games continued to increase, and the Paralympic Movement only rose alongside an expanding parasport audience. Today, the Paralympics have reached such commendable heights that it has its own organization: the International Paralympics Committee. Now, these Games are recognized as the second largest sporting event in the world.

After a struggle to receive recognition as equals of the Olympic Games, the Paralympic Games now exist parallelly with the Olympics, with neither Games considered more or less important than the other.

Our motherland, Bharat, has also experienced her fair share of victory in the Games. Specially-abled athletes like Devendra Jhajharia have been smashing records and bringing glory to our country, surpassing the pre-existing prejudices imposed upon them.

Our athletes have been performing remarkably over the years, but this year, Indians across the world saw something that left them astonished.

The 2024 Paris Paralympics have proven to be India's most successful campaign with a staggering medal tally of 29 medals - seven golds, nine silvers and thirteen bronzes. Apart from this exceptional display by the Indian contingent, there were a few individuals who enshrined India's name upon the history books by not just putting up medal-winning performances but setting world records.

The ace javelin thrower Sumit Antil broke his own world record twice, bringing home the second gold medal in two successive Paralympic editions.

The archer Sheetal Devi became India's youngest Paralympic medalist ever when she stole the show with her lethal arrows. She, along with Rakesh Kumar, set a new mixed compound world record, winning a bronze medal for India.

The awe-inspiring stories of such Paralympians, who overcame their disabilities from the moment they opened their eyes, transcend the world of sports, serving as beacons of inspiration to anyone facing adversity.

Despite the achievements and hard work of our athletes, our country and her people are somewhat failing them when it comes to appreciation. If we compare India's performance in the Paralympics to that of the Olympics, we actually seem to have done much better in the former. Yet, Paralympians continue to endure anonymity?!

Even with this disappointing absence of encouragement and gratitude, India's Paralympians continue to give their best for our country. It is now our responsibility to respect and motivate them, as they bring great pride and glory to Bharat.



THE COST OF FASHION

DHRITI SAVANI | IB I YEAR, CIRS

In a world where fashion trends circulate at the speed of light through social media, we instantly become delighted at the prospect of following the latest fads. But how often do we pause to appreciate the people who put their hard work into crafting these products? The skilled craftsmen whose artistry breathes life into our wardrobes are never given a second thought, let alone any credit. Most importantly, we fail to consider the environmental impact of our clothing choices - the resources consumed and the waste generated.

The fashion industry isn't just a commercial realm; it's a complex web of artistry and culture. In recent times, sustainability has often been compromised for the sake of fleeting trends. Many of us choose our favorite clothing labels to express ourselves, but do we take their origin into consideration?

The fabric industry is the second-largest consumer of water as it needs a voluminous amount of freshwater for processing of textiles. Washing certain types of clothes sends a significant amount of microplastics into the oceans, and even contributes to freshwater pollution through unused dyes that are released into water bodies. After all this, 85% of all fabrics are thrown away each year! Furthermore, countless textile workers - primarily women in developing countries - are often paid low wages, and are forced to work for long hours in primitive conditions.

The environmental and social costs of the fashion industry urge us to reconsider fast fashion. They highlight the need for more sustainable business models and practices. But who is to blame for all this? The industrialists? The manufacturers? In my opinion, it is consumers like us who are subconsciously promoting unethical modes of fashion by investing in brands that commit such deeds. Think about it! Do we really take the effort to look into the practices of the companies we buy from? How aware are we of the impact of our purchasing decisions?

By becoming more conscious shoppers, we can contribute to meaningful change in the industry. But how? The answer is sustainable fashion. Simply put, this refers to the manufacture and usage of clothing and accessories in an environmentally friendly and socially responsible way.



Options such as thrifting, second-hand shopping and vintage boutiques are all excellent choices for anyone wishing to update their wardrobes in a sustainable way. Moreover, customers can support firms that use sustainable methods by seeking certifications that demonstrate a company's commitment to ethical manufacturing.

As we stand at the crossroads of fashion and sustainability, the decisions we make today will undoubtedly affect the landscape of our planet tomorrow. Every garment we choose carries a story - of labor, resources and the environment. It is our responsibility to ensure that the values of fairness and ecological well-being are reflected in textile manufacturing. We, as consumers, hold the power to influence the fashion industry profoundly. At the end of the day, sustainable fashion offers more than just a change in our wardrobes - it holds the key to a better future.



College Success: The CIRS Spell

BHAKTI T. | FOUNDER - GIRL UP MAHATTVA | ALUMNA

Before I went to college, everyone told me that it'd be a "wild" experience. So that's exactly what I was expecting when I joined the London School of Economics (LSE). At first, I would wake up and wait every day with bated breath for the "wild" to sneak up and surprise me. But after one full year of college and nary a wild card in my arsenal, I have realized that the reason for this is the 6 years I spent at CIRS.

Firstly, what do CIRS students consider wild? Our imagination extends to excitement, diversity, cultural clash, and a little bit of anarchy. But I have come to realize that after CIRS, no amount of "wild" can compare to the life we have experienced here. An odd sociocultural phenomenon, isn't it?

I have now come to see that I have been prepped with everything I will need for my adult life right here at CIRS.

I don't find it difficult to attend my 9 AM lectures that other students cry about after our 6 AM jogging sessions, for I am used to these.

I don't find the 300-page readings every week hard to keep up with after the EEs and IAs in IB. And I don't get homesick like my friends because I know the trick is to "remember" rather than "miss" my parents.

Of course, who can forget the constant preparations during all the festivities? The Sundays were spent either writing culture talks, or preparing for the next big festival. So when someone asks me if my present life is hard I say, "No, I really could not be more prepared!"

I have already experienced all the wildness in CIRS. In a safe environment where growth was the result of conflict. Life becomes a cakewalk once you see that in CIRS you have trained yourself to simply survive without.

LSE, the place where I currently study Anthropology, is a truly diverse place. Here we have been "on the grind" since day one.

In fact, I think of LSE as a mini-CIRS because here I find the same socio-cultural phenomenon of like-



LSE MEMORIES

minded people in a race against themselves; all striving to achieve maximum growth of their character.

However, I can't deny the yet-to-be-colored canvas that is university life. Especially since LSE is in London, one of the busiest cities in the world, your life feels limitless. Sometimes it all gets a little overwhelming, but the CIRS training takes over again and I pick myself back up. Some days I let myself sleep in, knowing that my RHP will not wake me up. But is it crazy that even in London, where the world is truly my oyster, I miss those wake-up calls, 6 AM jogs, 5 PM sports, 7 PM aartis, and half-day Saturday routines.

Unspoken Words

ANIRUDDHA KOGANTI | GRADE 10, CIRS

In silence, whispers linger untold;
Unspoken words like secrets unfold.
They dance within the heart's chambers,
Where emotions ebb, never to remember.

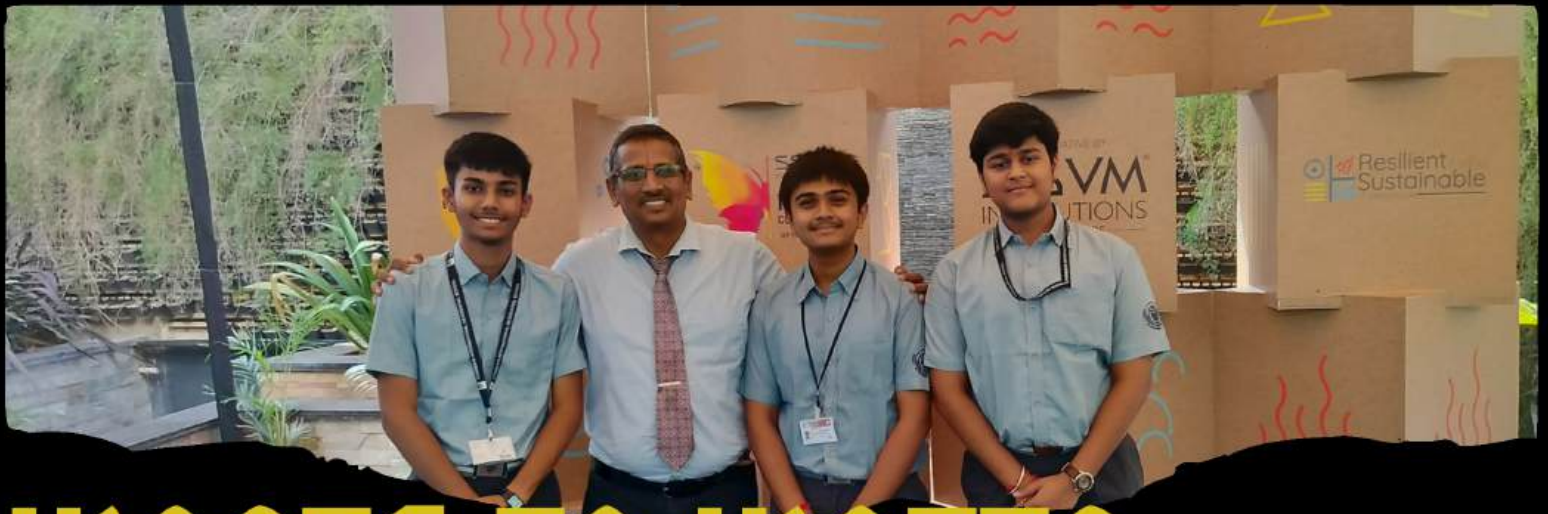
In the night's stillness they roam,
Echoes of feelings searching for home.
Yet they remain elusive, veiled,
A silent symphony of tales curtailed.

In the silence there lies power,
In the unspoken, a hidden mirror.
For sometimes, what's left unsaid
Speaks louder than words spread.

In the realm of the unspoken, we find
The echoes of the heart,
And the ties that bind.
For in the quiet, we learn to listen

To the language of the soul,
Unspoken...





WASTE TO WATTS

*Studentpreneur
Competition Report*

GATIK, JAYAM, ARNAV | GRADE 11, CIRS

"And the winner of the SSVM Studentpreneur Award for 2024-25 is... Team Vayu Nigrah!" These words of our host resonated like music to our ears. At that moment, the three of us felt like we were on top of the world! It was the SSVM Studentpreneur competition, where the top 10 teams from across the country had come to present groundbreaking ideas.

As we arrived at SSVM, the warmth of our hosts made us feel right at home as they guided us to the hall where all our determination and hard work over the past two months would be put to the ultimate test. Each pitch was more impressive than the last, but we knew we had something unique to offer. Yet, deep down, our nerves flickered like a candle in the wind. Finally, it was our turn to take the stage. With a deep breath, we started with our pitch.

Around a year ago, we were standing in front of an A/C vent. As we stood there, we realized that the A/C was blowing out some really hot air at a great velocity. On further investigation we figured out that there are several issues with A/C units. These not only increased the demand for cooling solutions, but also amplified energy consumption, thus creating a vicious cycle that impacted both the environment and our wallets. For this we found one simple solution: Vayu Nigrah. By channeling this hot exhaust air into turbines near A/C exhaust outlets, we can convert this otherwise wasted energy into electricity. The benefits are manifold: users see a reduction in their electricity bills by generating their own power, and this system also contributes positively to environmental sustainability. Our innovative product was perfectly encapsulated by our tagline - "Waste to Watts: Clean Energy Redefined," as per our vision - "Innovating For The Earth."

Then, it was time to announce the winners of the competition, and to our surprise, we emerged victorious, clinching the top spot in the competition! The thrill of holding those trophies, the gleaming

certificates, and a jaw-dropping prize of 1 lakh rupees were simply surreal! The cherry on top was receiving heartfelt praise from Mr. Srikanth Bolla himself during his speech. What an unforgettable experience it was!

This journey was about more than just winning an award. The SSVM Studentpreneur competition taught us creativity, teamwork and resilience, even as we transformed our idea into a viable solution. We learned to navigate competition and adapt to challenges, greatly enriching our knowledge of entrepreneurship. Every moment - from the nervousness before our pitch to the electrifying energy of the conclave - has heightened our understanding of entrepreneurship and innovation. As we reflect on this experience, we carry with us not just the trophy but a commitment to create meaningful change through more innovations like Vayu Nigrah.



Expecting: a Burden?

RITIKA DEORAH | GRADE 9, CIRS

Let me tell you something about the world: everyone is bound by expectations. Each individual expects themselves to do something in their lives, whether in the long-term or short-term. All of us fall prey to expectations at some point or the other. The worst thing, though, is that we not only impose our expectations on ourselves but create vivid expectations for those around us too. And before we know it, we start forcing these expectations onto them. There was once a little girl who had always wanted only one thing: to make her parents proud. But along the way, she unknowingly started mixing up the expectations she had set for herself with the expectations of her family. Eventually, their views about her became what she expected of herself.



Even if you care about the expectations of those around you, those people should be ones who truly matter in your life. After all, it is these very people who have seen you grow, and wish nothing but the best for you. Now that she had realized her mistake, the little girl began to carefully curate her priority list. For she knew that her expectations from herself were the ones that truly mattered the most. Although there were still people who told her she was letting them down, she was ready for it this time. She wasn't going to lose her mind once again to the demons of her past. Now she had learned to focus on herself and those close to her. No one else had a say in her life!

All of us have this little girl (or boy) within us, and these little ones deserve a chance to live a life where they are not bound by the expectations of the world. We need to give ourselves a chance to set our own priorities by doing what is beneficial and joyful for us. At the same time, this article is not a justification for mediocrity. Matching up to expectations is an accurate yardstick of one's personal growth, and can motivate us to work harder. But the expectations you set should be the right ones.

A lot of us let the views of those around us affect our actions, and only when we face their consequences do we realize the impact of our foolishness. We need to stop being people-pleasers and instead focus on ourselves. So what if they call us selfish or egoistic? This is our life, and we deserve to live it by our own standards. Now I let the little girl inside me beam with pride as I go through every day in my life, learning to live up to no expectations but my own. That little girl? She's finally grown up.

And soon, without realizing it, she had lost herself in this world of endless expectations.

"Every small task given to me has to be done perfectly!" was her constant mantra. Letting someone down seemed like a sin. While being an excellent quality by itself, this never allowed her to discover her true self. Her parents had always expected her to be an all-rounder - and that she most definitely was. And yet, she found herself somewhat falling short of her personal goals.

As she grew older, it became difficult to manage all her co-curricular activities while still excelling at academics. Growing up, she had rarely disappointed anyone. So now that it was actually happening, she had no idea what to do.

She considered listening to her friends, who frequently advised her that taking a step back sometimes was alright. But being the headstrong girl that she was, she brushed it off, confident that she could manage.

And mind you, she did - just not forever. Eventually, inevitably, she broke down. Her grades plummeted, she barely won any competitions, and as for sports - Neville Longbottom could have knocked her down! Her mind and heart were constantly at war - one wanting to push through and do it all, the latter on the precipice of breaking down. The petty ghosts of the world were unleashing the demons within her.

She spoke to her teachers and her parents, and they all said the same thing: expectations are merely a path to your goal and your purpose. The expectations you have for yourself should be the only ones that affect you.

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For no matter what happens it's this pressure that will make you perfect. But the catch is to never become too relaxed. After all, pressure is the only thing which can change carbon into diamond.

99

PRESSURE MAKES PERFECT

Anandini Gauri Nangia / Grade 7, CIRS

Exams. Before I came to this school, I didn't know that such a simple word could invoke fear in the hearts of millions and wipe the smile off any student's face. But the question is: why do we behave so strangely or get a mini heart attack every time we hear this word?

The amount of pressure the education system puts on us is insane but necessary, and it's definitely not going to get any easier. In fact, your geography teacher might have told you that as you climb higher the pressure decreases. Unfortunately, that's atmospheric pressure and not life pressure. Now it's exams, then you will have a job, soon you will have taxes, and later you will have grandchildren.

Another thing that exams never fail to bring is fear. Fear of failing, of coming last and of parents.

At this stage, you can let that fear push you down, or just dust yourself off and get back up. To quote my grandfather, "Just bounce back!"

We all know that fear comes from ignorance. So if you learn about the source of your fear it might disappear. It's a hard world out there, but you will have to be harder. Everyone has different ways to deal with stress, but my suggestion is to cultivate something that I call the 'Laxmi Effect'. Confused? Let me explain. Laxmi is the last name of one of my friends. She is that one special friend who is super laid back no matter what happens. Even if the world is going to end, she'll look like she's having a blast!

Although this may seem silly and unrealistic, it's true that sometimes, you just need to relax. So I suggest you find your Laxmi, that one person who will simply not let you crack under the pressure. For no matter what happens, it's this pressure that will make you perfect. But the catch is to never become too relaxed. After all, pressure is the only thing which can change carbon into diamonds. It will make you shine as long as you allow it to mold you instead of resisting it. Having said that, relaxation is only a way to cope and not a way to grow. You should never be too chill, as this will make you dull and dreary.

Last year, I gave an exam for literally the first time in my life! I was taking it very seriously, and had decided that I had to beat my brother at any cost. However, if Laxmi hadn't been there for me, I don't know how I would have survived. I only thank God for making these blessed people walk into my life. All of their teachings - from the subtlest to the most profound ones - have made an everlasting impact on me.

To sum up, I've learnt one major thing from all the people I've met so far: balance! The world is going to hit you in ways you cannot imagine. You need a proper backup plan to remain on your feet. It does get confusing sometimes, but that's just life with its twists and turns, ups and downs. The thing is, it's only going to get harder later, so enjoy things as they are now, even as you prepare for the future.





GANESH CHATURTHI - JUST A FESTIVAL?

DEVIKA DHELIA | GRADE 8, CIRS

The most awaited festival of the year had finally arrived! For 10 fun-filled days, CIRS was a flurry of activity; a period of joy and celebration. Throughout the year, the whole school waits eagerly for this particular festival to begin and brighten everyone's mood - Ganesh Chaturthi!

The history behind this ancient festival goes all the way back to the struggle for Bharat's freedom. Our great forefathers believed in oneness, and trusted us with the future of the nation. Hindu, Jain, Muslim or Sikh, it didn't matter! All these people were united in their desire to see a free Bharat. Many lion-hearted individuals took up this noble mission as their sworn duty; and in those dark times, one such beacon of light was Bal Gangadhar Tilak. He inspired thousands of Bharatiyas to stop hiding and suppressing themselves under the British, and instead urged them to celebrate their culture proudly in public areas. His vision was to foster a sense of unity in all, so they could contribute in the fight for independence.

Coming to the present day, this festival - that even we at CIRS celebrate - is a major reason behind the freedom movement's ultimate success. If we live peacefully in our homes today without any worry, it is because of the uniting power of our festivals. As Ganesh Chaturthi approaches, I always run to my grandparents' home in Mumbai, the city where you find the largest idols, with the smallest ones being 5ft high! Hundreds of devotees come to witness this magnificent festival

which is dear to all Bharatiyas since ancient times.

A day before the festival begins, people bring home Ganesha idols; throughout the days of revelry, there are flowers and colors as far as the eye can see. And of course, Bappa's name is chanted non-stop throughout the day! The most unforgettable part of the festival is, undoubtedly, visarjan. Bidding goodbye to Bappa, we do one final pooja and let Him go with devotion in our hearts and a mix of joy and tears on our faces.

As we saw earlier, Bharatiya festivals are celebrated to bring all of us together as one people. But if we look around us today, we see so many people misusing and misinterpreting these very celebrations to put down other religions and cultures. However, we must remember that we are citizens of Bharat, whose constitution states that we are a secular nation, with all religions given the same value. Here, we believe that the entire world is one family - Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam. But again a question arises in my mind: do we really consider ourselves a united, unbreakable family? Or do we nurse long-held grudges behind our masks of friendship?

We learn many significant life lessons from the festival of Ganesh Chaturthi, as we can from all our festivals. But for me, the most important one is its illustrious history as one of Bharat's uniting factors over the ages - a truly impressive legacy for us to celebrate as proud Bharatiyas.

I TRANSFORM



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Transformation comes only when we change our whole vision of life! Vedanta says, “Look at your life as a whole; not fragmented, not in parts.”

Swami Chinmayananda

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Join us for a captivating journey of self-discovery and national transformation. Based on the inspiring book "Transforming Indians to Transform India," our theatre show will take you on a transformative experience. Through powerful storytelling and mesmerizing performances, we'll explore the seven pillars of personal and national growth: Physical, Emotional, Intellectual, Spiritual, Patriotic, Cultural and Universal. Discover how these principles can empower you to make a positive impact on your life and society. Don't miss this opportunity to be inspired and uplifted! Experience the magic of dance and witness the transformative power of human potential.

Date - 15th October

Time - 7:00 PM

"Individual Transformation alone brings about World Transformation"

CHILDHOOD NOSTALGIA

NIYATI BHUKANIA | GRADE 9, CIRS

She was optimistic and carefree,
She was everything that happiness ever wanted to be.
She never waited to see what life had in store for her,
For she was the writer of her own destiny.
She never understood what they meant by insecurity,
Because for her, she was as perfect as she could be.

She was the master of her own will,
Even when the world fell silent and still.
Even if some days her life felt like a never ending haze,
She was still a shimmering soul in a mystical daze.
She was the shoulder on which to cry,
She was the person on whom to rely,
For she was no myth and she was no lie.
She was a person who always spoke her mind,
For her opinion to be heard she would go any mile.

I know I will always have her by my side,
Even in the darkest of times,
Because everyone has a lesson to learn and a tale to tell,
And this is mine!



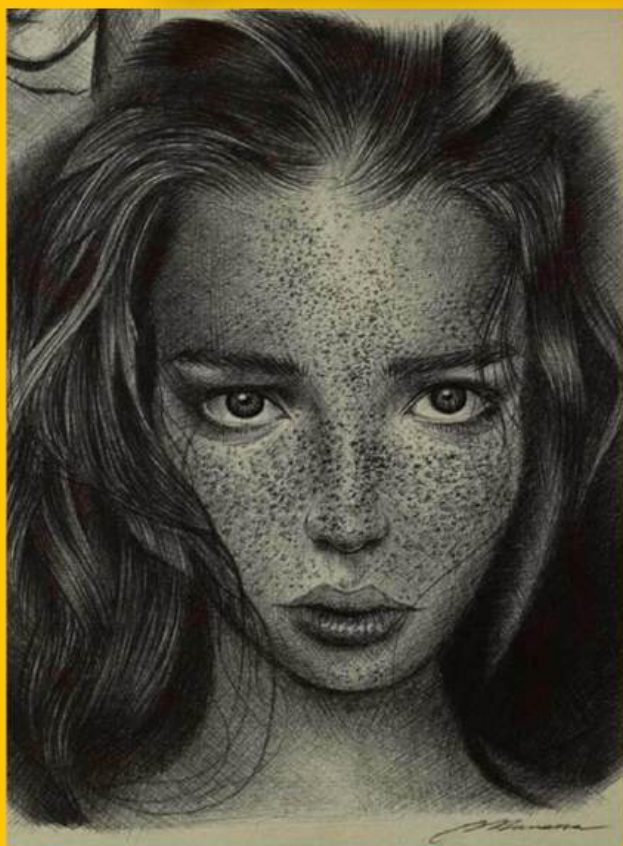
Captures







CREATIVE CORNER



V. Manassa - IB II 🏆



Radha G. - X 🏆



Ronav A. - VI 🏆



Naitik A. - X 🏆



J. Nidharshan - VII 🏆



Shaurya C. - VIII 🏆



Gatik C. ~ XI 📷



Anandini N. ~ VII 🎨



Tarushi A. ~ X 🎨



S. Rithesh ~ VII 🎨



Naman T. ~ VI 🎨



Eklavya A. ~ VII 🎨



Hari Narayan S. ~ VIII 🎨



Abarna R. ~ XI 📷



Arth A. ~ VII 🎨



Kishan V. ~ X 🎨



M. K. Prateethi ~ XI 🎨



Vedant A. ~ VI 🎨



CLASSIFIEDS



Love is a consistent passion to give, not a meek persistent hope to receive.
The only demand of life is the privilege to love all.

September - October 2024 | Living the Vision of the Visionary



The Editorial Team - '25

The Crossroads is CIRS' very own monthly newsletter that is truly for, of and by the students. We seek to foster literary excellence, promote language creativity and amplify voices that need to be heard. Best wishes to the new Editorial Team '25 as they take up the mantle and carry forward this vision with high hopes!

Rishi Suresh Iyer
Editor - Crossroads '24



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Our gratitude to the CIRS management for giving flight to our initiative.

Chinmaya International Residential School

Swami Chinmayananda Lane, Nallur Vayal Post, Siruvani Main Road
Coimbatore - 641114, Tamil Nadu, India



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